$ PORTABLE SYSTEM CONTEXT

Stop Re-Teaching Your Repo to Every Coding Agent.

Make context **portable**, **reviewable**, **fresh**, and **testable** before the agent edits. The repo is today's venue; the pattern applies to any system an agent must understand before acting.

SYSTEM NAVIGATION TRACK | .AGENT-CONTEXT/ | 288 GRADED ANSWERS | 6 REPOS · 4 MODEL VARIANTS

SPEAKER

Amit Prusty

Cursor Meetup · Amsterdam · May 2026

REPO

github.com/cote-star/agent-context

Amit Prusty

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I build the **operating layer around AI agents** — context, evals, workflows, and production adoption. Today, coding agents are the venue because this is a developer room.

AT WORK — Edelman

Building **agentic platforms** for communications: listening and new media signals, agentic PR workflows, and measurement that connects activity to outcomes.

Comms futures	listening, new media, and agentic PR
Attribution	earned media to outcomes and brand lift
Platforms	context, evaluation, controls, workflows

AGENTIC PR · LISTENING · ATTRIBUTION · PLATFORM SYSTEMS

OSS — github.com/cote-star

Two projects around `agent-context`: one for agent evidence, one for local control.

agent-chorus — SESSION EVIDENCE LAYER

A **read / search / compare** surface across Claude, Codex, Cursor, and Gemini: timelines, diffs, citations, and cross-agent QA.

latchkeyd — LOCAL CONTROL PLANE

A workstation control plane for trusted local agent workflows: approvals, boundaries, and repeatable tool access.

AT WORK → *Both sides teach the same lesson:* **AI gets useful after the demo.** ← OSS

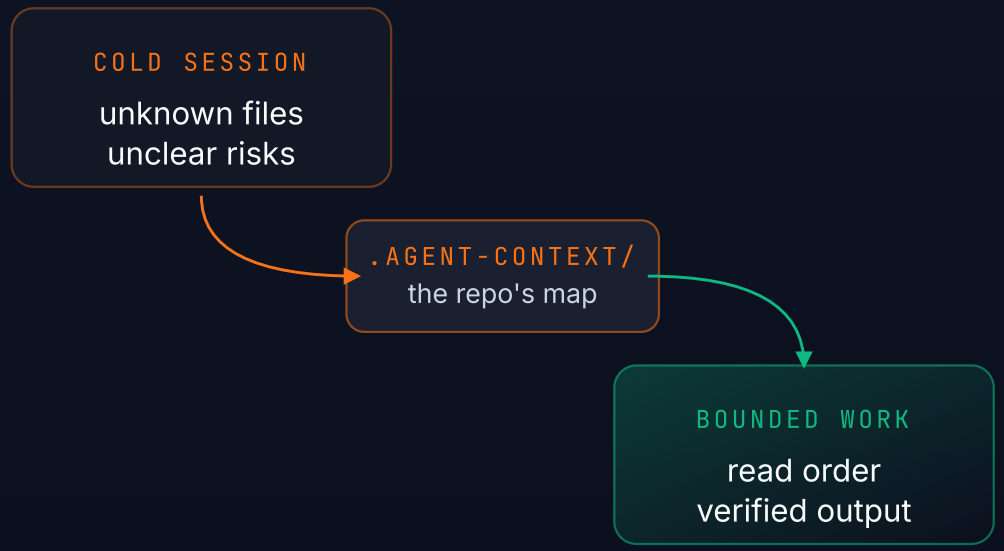
THE HOOK

The agent is new here every time.

Most coding agents enter a repo as a bright visitor with no durable map.

- They rediscover the tree.
- They infer ownership from whatever file they open first.
- They miss the invariant that decides whether an answer is safe.
- They repeat the same exploration in the next session, editor, or model.

> **A cold session** — unknown files, unclear risks, expensive search — gets converted into **bounded work** only when the repo carries its own map.



READ THE MAP BEFORE EDITING THE REPO

IT'S NOT THE MODEL

The failure is missing system evidence.

Software teams already check in tests, docs, schemas, CI, runbooks, and migration history.

Agent context should be another reviewable system artifact: the map of what is true, risky, connected, and out-of-bounds.

PORTABLE

Markdown / JSON, not vendor memory.

REVIEWABLE

Lives in git. Reviewed like code changes.

FRESH

Drift is a failing preflight, not a quiet footnote.

THE STANDARD IS SIMPLE

Read the system map before acting on the system.

NOT JUST REPO RECALL

Every serious system needs a navigation layer.

Code makes the problem visible. Portable context makes it general. This is not repo recall; it is a portable context pattern for any system with state, rules, risk, and work to do.

01	02	03	04 ← TODAY
Data platforms	Customer accounts	Ops runbooks	**Code repositories**

For this developer room, the system is a repo; the pattern travels anywhere an agent must explore, verify, and act.

THE ARCHITECTURE

Explorable system recall as a three-track pattern.

GLOSS · Explorable recall = an agent can re-discover the same map any time, on its own, from reviewable system artifacts.

agent-context works when **navigation**, **operating loop**, and **engineering** are treated as separate controls.

NAVIGATION

What should load, what should not, when should it stop?

control surface — read order / risky paths

OPERATING LOOP

How does this agent consume repo context during real work?

agent behavior — trust route / verify route

ENGINEERING

What makes prior work durable, inspectable, reusable?

systems layer — manifest / tests / CI

OUTCOMES WHEN ALL THREE LINE UP

bounded loading · provenance · faster verified answers

TODAY'S SESSION

The Navigation track only.

Navigation = the control surface. What the agent loads, doesn't load, and when it stops.

WHAT TO LOAD

Completeness contracts that name every file family that must change together.

WHAT NOT TO LOAD

Search scopes that bound where the agent grep-walks.

WHEN TO STOP

Stop rules + verification shortcuts that say "you have enough to answer."

OUT OF SCOPE TODAY

Operating Loop and Engineering appear where needed; the main track is Navigation.

THE ARTIFACT · REAL REPO

`.agent-context/` — a committed folder.

No hosted service. No hidden memory. No editor lock-in. Numbered files give the agent a deterministic read order.

.agent-context — cote-star/agent-context

- current — CONTENT · AUTHORITY · NAVIGATION
  - 00_START_HERE.md — ROUTING
  - 10_SYSTEM_OVERVIEW.md — CONTENT
  - 20_CODE_MAP.md — CONTENT
  - 30_BEHAVIORAL_INVARIANTS.md — CONTENT
  - 40_OPERATIONS_AND_RELEASE.md — CONTENT
  - acceptance_tests.md — QUALITY
  - completeness_contract.json — AUTHORITY
  - manifest.json — QUALITY
  - reporting_rules.json — POLICY
  - routes.json — AUTHORITY
  - search_scope.json — NAVIGATION
- tools — QUALITY
  - check_freshness.sh — QUALITY
  - verify_agent_context.py — QUALITY

CONTENT

`00_*` through `40_*` · markdown map.

AUTHORITY

`routes.json` · `completeness_contract.json` .

NAVIGATION

`search_scope.json` + verification shortcuts.

QUALITY

`manifest.json` · `acceptance_tests.md` · `tools/` .

CURSOR CLAUDE CODEX GEMINI OPENCODE

Tier 1 = code map + search scope, 2 files. **Tier 3** = full pack, 11 files. Start tier 1; promote when the repo has cross-cutting invariants.

BEHAVIOR

Same navigation design, opposite agent loops.

TRUST-AND-FOLLOW

Claude · Gemini

Reads the pack as authoritative. Stops when the contract says done.

14 → 4 files opened
claude bare → structured

Compressed search → fewer files opened.

SEARCH-AND-VERIFY

Cursor · Codex

Bounds its grep to scoped directories and cross-checks verification shortcuts.

3 → 12 files opened
cursor — each verified against shortcut

Expanded proof burden → more verification, fewer dead ends.

Model-agnostic by construction. The routing block — `CLAUDE.md` / `AGENTS.md` / `.cursorrules` — points tools at `.agent-context/` before source exploration.

A REPEATABLE LOOP

The workflow: ask, author, verify, review.

01 **Ask agent** — type the skill request into Claude, Codex, Cursor, or OpenCode.

02 **Skill authors pack** — inventories subsystems, may scaffold with `init`, fills templates.

03 **CLI checks** — after authoring, run `verify` and `freshness`.

04 **PR diff** — review the generated context like code.

WHAT HAPPENS IN PRACTICE

STEP 1 **Agent request**
Ask the coding agent to use the skill and build context for the repo.

STEP 2 **Pack authoring**
The skill inventories the repo, scaffolds when needed, and fills reviewable files.

STEP 3 **Machine checks**
Run verify and freshness before the generated context lands in a PR.

```
# 1. in your coding agent
> Use the agent-context skill to build context for this repo.

# 2. agent authors the pack and opens a diff
#    it may call init internally as scaffold

# 3. after the agent opens the diff
$ agent-context verify .
$ agent-context freshness .
```

TAKEAWAY

A repeatable operating loop, not a magic prompt.

QUALITY GATE

What a reviewer actually checks.

The review target is the context **diff**, not the model's private memory.

FILE FAMILIES

Does the pack name every file family that must change together?

NEGATIVE GUIDANCE

Does it say which plausible files are deprecated, generated, or near-misses?

SILENT FAILURES

Does it call out the thing that can break without a compile error?

```
// .agent-context/current/30_BEHAVIORAL_INVARIANTS.md
# DO NOT TOUCH — auth/session.ts uses a non-obvious cookie schema.
Changing this without updating cookie/v2 will fail silently in prod
(no compile error; sessions invalidate overnight). See routes.json#auth.session.
```

Pull-request-style review of the context diff is the durable quality gate.

TEST PROTOCOL

How to test whether it works.

The methodology is deliberately boring:

PROTOCOL PIECE	WHY IT MATTERS
bare clone vs structured_fresh clone	Same repo, same task, only context changes.
Hard multi-hop tasks	Lookup tasks prove little; synthesis exposes wrong turns.
Grep-backed ground truth	Every expected file family is mechanically checkable.
Fixed-rubric grading	Answers are scored against expected paths and risk criteria.

Freshness is a hard experiment gate. If the pack is stale, the run fails before agents start.

Q2 2026 MULTI-AGENT RERUN

Quantified evidence.

288 GRADED ANSWERS | 48 CELLS | 6 REPOS | 4 MODEL VARIANTS | BARE | STRUCTURED_FRESH

AGENT / MODEL	BARE	STRUCTURED	Δ
Claude Opus 4.7 Trust-and-Follow	80% (4.80/6)	100% (6.00/6)	+20pp
Cursor `claude-opus-4-7-medium`	89% (5.33/6)	97% (5.83/6)	+8pp
Cursor `composer-2-fast` default	61% (3.67/6)	81% (4.83/6)	+20pp
Codex CLI `0.130.0`	72% (4.33/6)	78% (4.67/6)	+6pp

CLAUDE OPUS + STRUCTURED

6/6 perfect across all 6 repos.

COMPOSER-2-FAST

+20pp — biggest absolute lift.

RISK → 0

Codex (0.33→0.00) · Cursor Opus med (0.50→0.00).

CURSOR OPUS MED

−65% duration (219s→78s).

* **Risk-flag** = the agent confidently cites the wrong file or misses an invariant; acting on the answer would break production. · May 2026 rerun grading is LLM-provisional; historical audited rows remain marked in docs.

PER-AGENT · TRUST-AND-FOLLOW

Claude Opus 4.7 — 6/6 perfect under structured.

CORRECTNESS

+20pp

80% → 100%

TOOL CALLS / CORRECT

-38%

14.2 → 8.8

FILES OPENED / TASK

-40%

4.5 → 2.7

Interpretation. Claude consumes the pack as authoritative — opens fewer files; the top-level Grep tool is not invoked. Tool-call efficiency gain is the strongest of any lane.

REFERENCE	BARE	STRUCTURED	Δ
Risk-flag rate / 6 tasks	0.20	0.17	small
Median duration / task	65s	56s	-14%
Re-read rate same file twice	0.015	0.004	-73%
Citations / task	8.9	9.3	flat
Judge quality score	8.8	9.0	up
Dead ends / post-hit	0 / 0	0 / 0	perfect

6 cells / 36 graded tasks · agent-chorus/bare ran on Haiku (5h-session fallback) — reported separately.

PER-AGENT · SEARCH-AND-VERIFY

Cursor `claude-opus-4-7-medium`

MEDIAN DURATION

-65%

219s → 78s

RISK-FLAG RATE

0.50→0

eliminated

CORRECTNESS

+8pp

89% → 97%

Interpretation. Bare Opus medium is the slowest lane — heavy `glob` + `grep` recon before reads. Hop-count up = a feature: structured Opus reads more files near the answer to verify pack vs source.

REFERENCE	BARE	STRUCTURED	Δ
Tool calls per correct	8.3	7.9	small
Files opened / task	4.8	3.9	-19%
Hops to first correct file verification depth	0.83	1.42	↑ feature
Search-vs-read ratio	0.89	0.57	dropped
Verification-shortcut hit rate	n/a	0.15	new
Dead ends / post-hit	0.1 / 0	0 / 0	eliminated

6 cells / 36 graded tasks · daemon-reference/bare hallucinated writes on first attempt; recovered on retry, 6/6 final.

PER-AGENT · DEFAULT MODEL

Cursor `composer-2-fast` — the pack lifts the faster model.

CORRECTNESS

+20pp

61% → 81%

TOOL CALLS / CORRECT

-18%

5.6 → 4.6

RISK-FLAG RATE

0.67→0.50

still riskiest

Interpretation. Smallest duration lift (none) but largest correctness lift. Still the riskiest lane in both conditions — structured doesn't eliminate composer risk flags entirely. Lower citation count throughout — composer cites less by design.

REFERENCE	BARE	STRUCTURED	Δ
Median duration / task	111s	112s	flat
Files opened / task	2.9	2.6	small
Search-vs-read ratio	0.52	0.44	down
Verification-shortcut hit rate	n/a	0.17	new
Citations / task	5.3	5.6	flat
Dead ends / post-hit	0.2 / 0	0.1 / 0	down

6 cells / 36 graded tasks · polyglot-monorepo/structured hit a transient provider error on first attempt; recovered on retry, 6/6 final.

PER-AGENT · SEARCH-AND-VERIFY

Codex CLI `0.130.0` — trades wall-clock for correctness.

PACK UTILIZATION

97%

0.14 → 0.97 · no skimming

RISK-FLAG RATE

0.33→0

eliminated

MEDIAN DURATION

55→126s

slower (honest)

Interpretation. Codex is slower under structured — trades wall-clock for correctness. Pack utilization 97% means codex reads almost every file in `.agent-context/current/`. Verification-shortcut hit rate is the highest of any agent (19%).

REFERENCE	BARE	STRUCTURED	Δ
Correctness yes-rate	72%	78%	+6pp
Tool calls per correct	11.4	9.2	-19%
Files opened / task	6.2	5.1	-18%
Verification-shortcut hit rate	n/a	0.19	highest
Hops to first correct file verification depth	1.0	1.33	↑ feature
Judge quality score	8.9	9.3	up

6 cells / 36 graded tasks · all codex tokens are `cell_replicated` (per-cell session totals, not per-task).

TRUST THE NUMBERS

Measurement protocol. Scope, grading, limits.

SCOPE

288 graded tasks · 48 cells · 6 repos × 4 model variants × 2 conditions × 6 tasks. Same template across all repos.

GRADING

Outputs were graded against grep-backed ground truth with a fixed rubric. The May 2026 rerun is LLM-provisional; historical Claude rows include prior human audit.

PROTOCOL

Fresh-pack isolated. Every `structured_fresh` clone passed `agent-context verify` + `check_freshness.sh` before the agent started. Pack content authored at v0.2.0; validated at v0.3.1.

TELEMETRY CAVEATS

Cursor sessions in opaque SQLite — tokens/cost null in this rerun. Codex tokens are `cell_replicated` (per-cell session totals).

ANOMALIES PRESERVED · NOT MASKED

One repo was excluded after setup review. Retry/fallback anomalies are preserved in the run notes and excluded from headline claims where appropriate. **Working slate is 6 repos.**

Use headline claims as directional until reviewer-confirmed rows are marked in docs; historical audited rows remain part of the evidence base.

"ISN'T THIS JUST .CURSORRULES?"

How agent-context fits what you already do.

YOU ALREADY HAVE…	AGENT-CONTEXT
`.cursorrules` / `AGENTS.md` / `CLAUDE.md` single-file routing	Uses these as **routing blocks** pointing into the structured pack. **Not a replacement.**
MCP servers runtime tool access (web, DB, internal APIs)	Different layer. agent-context is the navigation map; MCP is access.
Vector search semantic recall over chunks	Pack is structural recall: deterministic file lists, contracts, verification shortcuts. **Use each where it fits.**
Cursor project memory / "rules for AI"	Pack supplements, doesn't replace. Pack lives in git; IDE memory may not.

For Cursor users specifically: `.cursorrules` already exists in your repo. agent-context adds the rest of the contract — completeness, search scope, verification shortcuts — and Cursor reads it natively.

NOT MAGIC

Tradeoffs.

MAINTENANCE COST

The pack must change when relevant code changes.

OVERFITTING RISK

Packs should route and bound search, not quote every answer.

REPO-SIZE FIT

Small repos may only need tier 1. Full packs scale to monorepos.

TELEMETRY GAPS

Cursor stores sessions in opaque SQLite; tokens/cost stay null without reverse-engineering.

HUMAN REVIEW REMAINS

Context improves first drafts; it does not replace code review.

EVIDENCE STATUS

Some rows are provisional until reviewer confirmation is marked in the docs.

THE BARGAIN

Spend a little context-maintenance effort to **stop every agent from rediscovering the same map.**

TRY THIS ON ONE REPO

Tomorrow.

01 **Install the skill once** — then open your target repo.

02 **Ask your agent** — use the `agent-context` skill to build the pack.

03 **Review the generated diff** — inspect the new `.agent-context/` pack.

04 **Run checks** — `verify` and `freshness`.

05 **Pick one painful workflow** — use it to test the pack's value.

The fastest path is not hand-authoring files. Let the agent create the pack; use the CLI to make it reviewable.

```
# ask your coding agent
> Use the agent-context skill to build context for this repo.

$ agent-context verify .
$ agent-context freshness .
# open a PR for the generated context diff
```

ANY AGENT THAT READS `AGENTS.MD`

...or runs in a repo can pick up the pack — Cursor, Claude Code, Codex, Gemini, OpenCode, plus JetBrains / VS Code Copilot.

$ MAKE CONTEXT PART OF THE SYSTEM

Make context part of the system.

Not a prompt trick. Not a vendor feature.
For developers, it starts in the repo. For teams, it becomes a reviewable system standard.

SKILL AUTHORS · VERIFY · FRESHNESS · REVIEWABLE PR

DO THIS WEEK

Pick one repo. Ask your agent to build the context pack. Verify it. Open a PR.

TODAY'S TRACK

Navigation. Operating Loop & Engineering = next conversations.

REPO · CONTACT

github.com/cote-star/agent-context

— Amit Prusty